PHOTOGRAPHS BY BOB CHAPMAN

An emerging bowl from English elm

Bob Chapman shows how he makes an emerging bowl which appears to be half in and half out of a solid block of elm

BOB CHAPMAN

After teaching chemistry for many years, Bob took early retirement to become a professional woodturner, and is a member of the Register of Professional Turners. He was a demonstrator at the 2009 AWGB Woodturning Seminar and is available for commissions.

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There is some doubt about the origin of English elm (*Ulmus minor* var. *vulgaris*), but it is almost certainly not England. The elm tree was once used for cattle food, constructional timber and shelter from the elements. There is archaeological evidence that Neolithic peoples carried the tree around Europe as they moved.

In the late 1960s Dutch elm disease struck the elms of Britain with devastating results, killing more than 25 million trees. Although the disease was identified in Holland, it is thought that it actually came to Britain in a shipment of elm logs from the USA. By the 1990s very few elms remained in Britain or in the rest of Europe. Rather surprisingly, the largest concentration of elms in Europe is in Amsterdam, although several thousand survived in Brighton in the UK after the council cut a 'firebreak' of elms around the city, effectively quarantining it from the rest of the country's elms.

The Conservation Foundation and the Natural History Museum have both mapped remaining elms in the UK, gathering information from ramblers and others who use the countryside. Linda and I found a single mature elm tree at Gunnerside in Swaledale in the Yorkshire Dales.

Elms are large and imposing trees and not too difficult to identify by this alone. Confirmation comes from the shape of the leaves and the unusual fact that they are somewhat lopsided where they meet the leaf stem, one side being lower than the other.

Elm timber has an interlocking grain which makes it very difficult to split and it has been traditionally used in circumstances where this is an advantage, for example chair seats, wagon wheels, coffins and ships' keels. It makes poor firewood and, according to folklore, 'elm-wood burns like churchyard mould, even the very flames are cold'. Elm has a very attractive red, brown, gold colour and it turns well and takes a good surface. I find it a wonderful wood to turn but one that is increasingly difficult to get hold of.

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